

BEYOND THE KINGDOM — World Building

Document 09 · Locked Canon · The World, the Country, Georgia & Atlanta (1905 – January 3, 2005)

PART 1 — THE RULES OF THIS UNIVERSE

1. **"The Real World, Plus."** *Beyond the Kingdom* takes place in the real United States of 2005, with the real President, the real wars, the real weather, and the real songs, plus a layer of fictional families, companies, and institutions.
 2. **Real history stays real.** September 11, the Iraq War, the Indian Ocean tsunami, and Hurricane Katrina all happen on their real dates. The show reacts to them respectfully and never exploits them.
 3. **Fictional officeholders (soap convention):**
 - Real public officials below the national level are **never named or impersonated**.
 - Atlanta's Mayor (Josephine Whitaker), the APD Chief (Elxa Jackson), the Fulton County DA (Arianna Cummings), and Jasmine Olson's congressional district are fictional.
 - The Governor and the state Attorney General are referred to only by title.
 - National figures (the President, for example) exist in the background but are never shown doing anything the real person didn't do.
 4. **No supernatural elements.** Every twist has to be possible, even if it's outrageous. This is soap realism: big feelings, real consequences.
 5. **Black excellence is the baseline, not the exception.** In this world, the two richest families on Earth are Black. The show treats that as history that happened, not as fantasy.
 6. **Continuity is sacred.** Anything that has aired is permanent.
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PART 2 — THE COUNTRY: THE UNITED STATES, JANUARY 2005

Politics

- **President George W. Bush** won re-election on **November 2, 2004**, and his **second inauguration is Thursday, January 20, 2005** (a preempted airdate). The country is bitterly divided after the 2004 election.
- **The 109th Congress convenes Tuesday, January 4, 2005.** Congresswoman Jasmine Olson (D-GA), the Donohues' eldest daughter, is sworn in for her **10th term** that day (Episode #2).
- **The Iraq War** is nearly two years old, and **Afghanistan** is in its fourth year. Military families and veterans are a real presence in Atlanta. BSI hires veterans aggressively.

- **Homeland security** is a boom industry after September 11, 2001. That boom made **BSI's** meteoric rise possible (2002–2005).

The Economy

- The **housing boom** is at its peak. Easy mortgages, flipping, and luxury condos are everywhere. It's the perfect moment for Harmony to become a broker, and for Smilley Estates to invade Atlanta.
- Gas averages about **\$1.80 a gallon**. It will spike after Katrina.
- Wall Street is recovering from the dot-com bust. The Donohues bought the bottom (2000–2002).

Technology (what people actually have in 2005)

- **Phones:** Flip phones (the **Motorola RAZR** is *the* status phone), **BlackBerrys** for executives, **T-Mobile Sidekicks** for the young and fabulous, and two-way pagers. Texting is new and addictive. **No smartphones, no iPhone (2007), no apps.**
- **Music:** iPods, burned CDs, ringtones.
- **Internet:** Dial-up is dying and broadband is spreading. People use AOL Instant Messenger (AIM), MySpace, BlackPlanet, LiveJournal, Xanga, Blogger, message boards, and email forwards. **Facebook is limited to college students. YouTube launches this year. Twitter and Instagram don't exist.**
- **TV:** Cable news, BET, UPN (*Girlfriends*, and in this universe Grace's *Sweet Tea*), *Chappelle's Show*, *American Idol*. DVRs (TiVo) are new.

Culture — The Soundtrack of 2005

- **Atlanta runs hip-hop and R&B:** OutKast, Usher, Ludacris, T.I., Ciara, Lil Jon and the crunk movement, and Jermaine Dupri's *So So Def*. The Atlanta sound is everywhere.
- Kanye West's *The College Dropout* is the album of the moment.
- In film, Jamie Foxx is winning everything for *Ray*, and Atlanta's own Tyler Perry is about to open *Diary of a Mad Black Woman* (Friday, February 25, 2005).
- **In this universe:** Grace Bullock's platinum album *Amazing Grace* (October 2004) and her single "Crown Me" are real chart hits.

Sports

- The **Atlanta Falcons** won the NFC South. They beat the Rams in the playoffs on **Saturday, January 15, 2005**, and lose the NFC Championship to the Eagles on **Sunday, January 23, 2005**. That's great background texture for January episodes.
- The Super Bowl is **Sunday, February 6, 2005**, in Jacksonville.

PART 3 — THE DIVERGENCE: HOW THE DONOHUES, SMILLEYS & BLACKWATER CHANGED THE WORLD

"The Donohue Economy"

- **Donohue Global Holdings is worth \$10 trillion**, roughly a fifth of the entire world economy. Its scale makes it a quasi-sovereign power:
 - Victor Donohue is invited to G8 summits as an "observer."
 - Presidents of both parties call him on the first ring.
 - Economists track the **"Donohue Index"**: when DGH moves capital, markets move with it.
- The **Donohue Foundation** gives away more than \$30 billion a year. **In this universe, HBCUs are among the best-endowed universities in America.** Spelman, Morehouse, Howard, and Xavier compete with the Ivy League for students and faculty, thanks to decades of Donohue money.
- **The Donohue Code of Conduct:** DGH's labor standards (the highest pay floor in every industry it touches) have quietly raised wages worldwide. Unions love Joan. Rivals hate Victor.

The Smilley Counterweight

- **Smilley International (\$1.9 trillion)** is the world's second-most-valuable private company. It is glamour to the Donohues' gravity. Its move to Atlanta in January 2005 is called **"the Second Great Migration of money."**
- **Cultural divide:** Team Donohue (old Southern legacy, faith, discretion) versus Team Smilley (Northern glamour, fashion, flash). Black America debates it at barbershops, beauty salons, and Sunday dinners.

Blackwater

- **BSI** has made private security a respectable, even beloved, industry in America, especially after its free disaster-relief deployments.
- **The Blackwater Syndicate** has quietly changed the underworld. Human trafficking in the Southeast has collapsed by 80%, because "Sovereign" hunts traffickers. Law enforcement can't prove any of it.
- **"Who is Sovereign?"** is a national parlor game, the way "Who shot J.R.?" once was.

Black Wealth in This Universe

- There are "two Americas" of Black wealth. There's the **Donohue and Smilley stratosphere** (families worth hundreds of billions). Then there's the thriving Black professional class beneath it: the Bakers, the Cummingses, the Divines. That class exists in real life, and the show honors it.
- **The show never forgets the middle class.** Harmony, Calvin, and Loretta Divine remind everyone how the other 99% of Atlanta lives.

PART 4 — GEORGIA, 2005

- **Capital:** Atlanta. The Gold Dome (the State Capitol) is where Jasmine's gubernatorial ambitions and Arianna's Attorney General dreams will play out.
- **Politics:** Georgia is shifting. Rural Georgia and the suburbs lean one way, and Atlanta leans hard the other. The Donohues are the state's biggest political donors, through Alvin's fundraising and Victor's checkbook.
- **Georgia places on the show's map:**

Place	Story Use
Americus / Sumter County	Alexander's birthplace. BSI's 9,000-acre Sumter Center training campus is here.
Savannah	The Savannah Betrayal (1952). The Jones Street house. The Port of Savannah (the Onyx coin crates).
Sea Island / St. Simons	Where Georgia's elite summer. The Crest Resorts compound.
Metter (Candler County)	The one-room roadside motel (Episodes #156–157)
College Park	Rochelle Banks' salon. Tremaine's world. Near Hartsfield-Jackson.

PART 5 — ATLANTA, 2005: "THE BLACK MECCA"

The City

- The **city** has roughly 450,000 people, and the **metro** area nearly 5 million.
- **Hartsfield-Jackson** is the busiest airport on Earth.
- Atlanta is home to **Spelman, Morehouse, Clark Atlanta, and Morris Brown** (the Atlanta University Center), the **King Center**, **Ebenezer Baptist**, and **Sweet Auburn**.
- In this universe, Atlanta is also the world headquarters of the **two most valuable companies on Earth**. The Buckhead skyline is defined by the rival towers: **Donohue Tower** (88 stories) and **Smilley Tower** (72 stories), which face each other across Peachtree Road.
- Atlanta's nickname in-universe: "**The Capital of Black Royalty**."

The Class Map of Atlanta

Area	Who Lives There	Show Characters
Northwest Buckhead (30327)	Old money, the ultra-elite	Belmont Crest (the Donohues, Cummingses, Bakers), Ravenhurst (the Smilleys)
Buckhead Village / Peachtree corridor	Nightlife, luxury towers, shopping	Amond's penthouse, Velvet, Sanctuary, Lenox Square, Phipps Plaza

Area	Who Lives There	Show Characters
Midtown	Young professionals, media, arts	BSI Tower, Martin's loft, Piedmont Park, WBKG studios
Virginia-Highland	Bohemian, historic homes	Elxa & Jeremy's Craftsman
Downtown	Government and courts	City Hall, the Fulton County Courthouse, the Gold Dome
Sweet Auburn / Old Fourth Ward	Historic Black business district, and the birthplace of the Donohue empire	The old Hotel Donohue , the Auburn Avenue Revival battleground
West End	Historic, working-class, and proud	Dee's Kitchen (Mama Dee), barbershops, the Southside Syndicate
Cascade Heights (Southwest Atlanta)	Established Black middle and upper-middle class	The Divine family home
College Park / South Fulton	Working and middle class	Rochelle & Tremaine Banks

Institutions & Power (In-Universe)

Pillar	Institutions	Key Players
Money	Donohue Global Holdings, Smilley International, BSI	Victor, Natasha, Lucius, Esther, Marc
Law	Atlanta Police Department (HQ: City Hall East, 675 Ponce de Leon Ave.), the Fulton County DA, the FBI Atlanta Field Office, Bullock & Associates	Elxa, Jeremy, Hughes, Arianna, Doyle, Robert
Politics	City Hall, the City Council, the Gold Dome, Congress	Mayor Whitaker, Councilman Hardaway, Jasmine
Medicine	Atlanta Presbyterian Medical Center (fictional), Grady Memorial, Piedmont Hospital, Egleston Children's	Peter, Yvette, Loretta
Faith	Greater Crest Tabernacle AME (fictional), Ebenezer, and the Black church network	Bishop and First Lady Lyons
Society	Belmont Crest Country Club, the Magnolia Cotillion, and real Black social institutions (the Links, Jack and Jill, the Divine Nine fraternities and sororities, the Boulé)	Percy Langston, Joan, Natasha
Media	<i>The Atlanta Sentinel</i> (fictional), WBKG Channel 8 (fictional), <i>Atlanta Daily World</i> , <i>Jet</i> , <i>Ebony</i> , <i>Essence</i> , CrestWatch	Bernadette Sinclair, Celeste Vaughn, Connie (secretly)
Underworld	The Blackwater Syndicate, the Merriweather Organization	Sovereign, The Seven, Silas Merriweather

Standing Sets (Production)

The Summit, Belmont Crest:

- Donohue Manor: living room, library, dining room, terrace
- The Dowager House: gallery porch and parlor
- Belle Rive (the Bullock estate)
- The Bullock Pavilion (Marc's glass living room)
- The Olson Estate, including the surgical suite

Belmont Crest community:

- Country Club: the Alexander Grill and the Simone Ballroom
- The Crown Gate guardhouse
- The River Gate boathouse (the Blackwater Table)
- The Lake Simone gazebo
- Belmont Crest Chapel and Greater Crest Tabernacle

Ravenhurst: grand hall, Esther's library, the nursery

Corporate offices:

- Donohue Tower: Victor's 88th-floor office and the boardroom
- Smilley Tower: Esther's office
- BSI Tower: Marc's 58th-floor penthouse office

Law and government:

- APD: the Chief's office and an interrogation room
- The DA's office
- Bullock & Associates: Robert's office

Nightlife, homes, and other regular spaces:

- Velvet nightclub, with a VIP section
- Dee's Kitchen
- Amond's penthouse
- Harmony's house
- Elxa & Jeremy's kitchen
- Atlanta Presbyterian Medical Center: nurses' station and patient room
- WBKG newsroom and anchor desk

PART 6 — THE MEDIA & INTERNET ECOSYSTEM (the "Fans" Layer)

In this universe, the Donohues and Smilleys are the most-covered families in America. Fans follow them like royalty and celebrities combined.

Platform (2005)	How It's Used on the Show
<i>The Atlanta Sentinel</i>	Front-page headlines, business-page wars, Bernadette's "Behind the Gates" column
WBKG Channel 8	Breaking news, Celeste's exclusives, the Sovereign Broadcast (#38)
<i>Jet*</i> / <i>Ebony</i> / <i>*Essence</i>	"Black Royalty" covers, wedding coverage, and polls: "Team Donohue or Team Smiley?"
<i>Forbes*</i> / <i>Fortune</i> / <i>*WSJ</i>	Net worths, the Tower War, BSI's rise
CrestWatch (Blogger)	The anonymous gossip blog that is always first. Written by Connie Donohue, revealed to the audience in #179.
"Find Dee" (LiveJournal)	Harmony's heartbreaking weekly posts
BlackPlanet & AOL message boards	Fan forums such as " KingdomWatchers ," " SovereignSightings ," and " Team Esther "
MySpace	Grace's official page (in-world, 2 million "friends"), Quentin's DJ page, Kiara's page
AIM / text messages	Private character conversations shown on screen

PART 7 — THE UNDERWORLD MAP OF ATLANTA (January 2005)

Organization	Territory	Leader	Status
The Blackwater Syndicate	Most of the city, the Southeast, and global through the Nassau Accord	Sovereign (Marc)	Dominant since the Sweet Auburn Truce (August 14, 2004)
The Merriweather Organization	Southside gambling, numbers, and loans. Seven funeral homes.	Silas Merriweather	Wounded and waiting
The Harlow Ring (defunct)	Buckhead nightlife trafficking (2000)	Vaughn Harlow	"Destroyed" in 2000. Harlow is secretly alive.
Martin Olson's network	No territory. Money, mercenaries, and blackmail.	Martin, with Cyrus Knox	Invisible, and growing

PART 8 — MASTER WORLD TIMELINE (1905 – January 3, 2005)

Date	Event
Mar 14, 1905	Alexander Donohue is born in Americus, Georgia

Date	Event
Aug 8, 1908	Cornelius Smilley is born in Vicksburg, Mississippi
Nov 2, 1910	Simone Toussaint is born in New Orleans
1921	Alexander walks to Atlanta with \$3
1924	Donohue Transfer Company is founded
Nov 2, 1931	Donohue Enterprises, Inc. is incorporated
Jun 10, 1933	Alexander marries Simone
Aug 1, 1936	The Hotel Donohue opens on Auburn Avenue
1938	Cornelius opens The Smilley in Chicago
1946	Cornelius marries Odessa Hart
Mar 7, 1952	The Savannah Betrayal
1955	<i>Holmes v. City of Atlanta</i> . Alexander begins the Buckhead Gambit.
Mar 15, 1958	Belmont Crest is founded
Jun 20, 1959	Victor marries Joan
Oct 24, 1959	The cross burning at the Crown Gate. "We stayed."
Apr 15, 1961	The Belmont Crest Country Club opens
Jan 3, 1966	Donohue Hospitality Group is formed, with Victor as CEO
Mar 1, 1971	Donohue Global Holdings and the Crown Trust are formed
1979	Joan is appointed a federal judge
1985	Bullock & Associates is founded
Feb 19, 1987	Cornelius dies. Lucius becomes Smilley CEO.
Jan 1987	Jasmine takes her seat in Congress
1989	Smilley International is named
1992	Donohue Tower opens
Jun 3, 1996	Victor becomes DGH Chairman. Natasha becomes DHG CEO.
Jul–Aug 1996	The Atlanta Olympics
Oct 13, 1996	The Codicil : Marc (14) is named Heir Apparent
Dec 31, 1999	Alexander dies at 11:58 PM
Jul 15, 2000	Grace is drugged at Harlow's party and rescued by Marc and Amond
Sep 29, 2000	The Blackwater Syndicate is founded at the River Gate
Apr 2001	Peter secretly rebuilds Harlow's face in Cancún
Jul 2001	Lyric is conceived (Amond & Harmony)
Sep 1, 2001	The Sag Harbor masquerade : the twins are conceived
Sep 11, 2001	The September 11 attacks
Jan 1, 2002	Arianna kills Darnell Divine . Marc covers it up.
Apr 16, 2002	BSI is founded

Date	Event
Apr 20, 2002	Lyric Solace Baker is born
May 10, 2002	Emma & Victoria Smilley are born in Chicago
2002–2004	Esther secretly builds Smilley Tower through "Peachtree Pinnacle Partners"
Mar 2003	Theodore sues to break the Codicil and loses. The Exile to Monaco begins.
Mar 14, 2003	The Nassau Accord: Blackwater goes global
Sep 20, 2003	Esther is named Smilley heir
Summer 2004	The Summer of Silence (Blackwater vs. Merriweather)
Aug 14, 2004	The Sweet Auburn Truce
Oct 16, 2004	Elxa marries Jeremy
Nov 2, 2004	Arianna is elected DA. President Bush is re-elected.
Nov 15, 2004	The FBI opens Operation Deep Water
Dec 9, 2004	Smilley announces its move to Atlanta
Dec 20, 2004	Elxa is sworn in as APD Chief
Dec 24, 2004	Sebastian proposes to Esther in Paris
Dec 26, 2004	The Indian Ocean tsunami. BSI Crisis Response deploys.
Jan 1, 2005	Arianna is sworn in as DA
Jan 2, 2005	The New Year's Crown Brunch
Jan 3, 2005	SERIES PREMIERE. Smilley Tower opens.

PART 9 — REAL 2005 CALENDAR FOR WRITERS (Season 1)

Events the characters can react to (and when):

Date	Real Event	How the Show Can Use It
Jan 4	The 109th Congress convenes	Jasmine's swearing-in (#2)
Jan 15 & 23	Falcons playoff win, then NFC Championship loss	Sunday-dinner arguments, and bets at the Club
Jan 17	Martin Luther King Jr. Day	Greater Crest service (#11)
Jan 20	Presidential Inauguration (preempted)	
Feb 6	Super Bowl XXXIX	Alvin's Miami party (mentioned only)
Feb 13	Grammy Awards	Grace attends (off-screen). CrestWatch covers her dress.
Feb 25	<i>Diary of a Mad Black Woman</i> opens	A date-night reference
Feb 27	Academy Awards	Watch party at Belle Rive
Mar 27	Easter Sunday	Delphine's photo (#60)
Apr 2	Pope John Paul II dies	Joan and Bishop Lyons on faith (background)

Date	Real Event	How the Show Can Use It
Jun 13	The Michael Jackson verdict	TV in the background at Dee's Kitchen
Jun 19	Juneteenth	The Belmont Crest Juneteenth Lawn Party (#119)
Aug 29	Hurricane Katrina	The Katrina arc (#167–#172)
Sep 2	Katrina news coverage (preempted)	

Real events are used as backdrop. Real people are never given fictional dialogue or actions.